unfold. Their strategy had three elements: strategically they would use the Sikkim Question as leverage for extracting concessions from India; optically they would appear as principled; tactically they would be flexible.

What were these Chinese objectives? First, the Chinese remained concerned about Tibet and the presence of the 14th Dalai Lama in India. Despite three decades of absolute control after the Dalai Lama had fled Tibet in March 1959, there was fresh unrest inside Tibet in 1989 (the thirtieth anniversary of the Dalai Lama's departure). Monks immolated themselves. The Chinese had to declare martial law in Lhasa in March 1989. The tenth Panchen Lama's death in the same year was also another problem; the Tibetans refused to recognize the Chinese candidate. In December 1988, the Chinese had persuaded Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi to acknowledge that Tibet was a part of the People's Republic of China, but he did so in a rather roundabout fashion and only as an 'autonomous region'. The Chinese believed they might use Sikkim for wresting a further admission of their sovereignty over Tibet from India. Second, Tibet's economic development had become a priority for the Chinese government in the 1990s, and trade with India offered an immediate opportunity for Tibet's development, as the road and rail links that have subsequently joined Tibet to the rest of China were absent at the time. Using Sikkim as the point of entry for Chinese products into India also circumvented the complications of doing trade across a disputed frontier. The Tibet–Sikkim boundary was the only part of the India–China boundary that China did not contest. As China's economy expanded, this option, thus, gained attraction. Not only did it, theoretically, allow for access to the Indian market but it was also an outlet for China to the Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean through the shortest possible route from the Chinese mainland. Thirdly, a settlement over Sikkim would also help to